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BJP. Chadha claimed to be in touch with over 60 AAP MLAs. A confidence motion by Mann in May passed with ony 88 votes from a party of 94. Seven AAP MLAs have been arrested since 2022, Pathanmajra and Arora among them. Sanaur and Samana are also in Patiala, where Congress won in 2024.

THE BATTLE FOR MALWA

AAP reads the room differently. Insiders told INDIA TODAY that Mann still commands popularity in the rural areas, especially Malwa, where the party won 66 of 69 seats—out of the state total of 117—in 2022. Recent results have been ambivalent. So former Punjab Congress chief Amrinder Singh Raja Warring and BJP state chief Kewal Singh Dhillon call the early list damage control in advance. It is an attempt to stop any further blood loss, allowing nominees to use development funds till the model code kicks in.

The three exits are not yet a signal of a serious exodus by MLAs in good standing—Pathanmajra, for instance, was booked in 2025 in a rape, cheating and criminal intimidation case, and evaded the police for nearly seven months before his arrest in March. But the fortress walls are being patrolled clearly with one eye to the inside. ■

KARNATAKA

The Blistering Season of Stings

Questions swirl around a purported sting video from the past—who shot it and why, is it fake, who leaked it now? Big fish in political cesspool

By **Ajay Sukumaran**

IT'S POLLEN THAT HANGS OVER BENGALURU usually, but this time, the season is of bee-stings, so to speak. Politically, there's a hornet's nest all stirred up. The first buzz came when chief minister D.K. Shivakumar advised his ministers, at a cabinet members in early October, to be wary of 'sting' operations. He claimed, without divulging details, that there had been an attempt to trap him and thus besmirch the Congress government, which he has been heading for five months now.

Weeks later, in a TV interview, he disclosed that a businessman wearing AI glasses had approached not just him but his Kerala counterpart V.D. Satheesan as well, and that he suspected a plot to target Congress governments.

Meanwhile, it turned out that a murky 'sting' saga had indeed been developing parallelly. In its cross-hairs was not DKS but his predecessor Siddaramaiah. He had stepped down as CM in May, and has been mulling retirement from elections, but it seems politics isn't ready to let go of him just yet.

On October 6, the ex-CM filed a cybercrime complaint about defamatory material circulating on social media and procured an injunction to get them taken down. It purportedly presented "two men and a woman in conversation" as a "secret or hidden-camera interaction" where "the woman is



STINGING RETORT Former Karnataka CM Siddaramaiah at a Congress rally in Bengaluru, Sept. 2

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